

FATEH CHAND BADHWAR (1900–95)

Independent India's first Railway Board chairman, Fateh Chand Badhwar, began his career with the East Indian Railway (EIR) Company in 1925. As the chairman, he presided over the successful unification of the lines, including those belonging to the Princely States. He also promoted the process of industrialization and modernization to ensure lesser dependence on Britain for rolling stock. The Research Design and Standards Organisation (RDSO), which focused on development, was established during his term. He was awarded the Order of the British Empire in 1946 and the Padma Bhushan in 1955.

Management matters

The year 1951 saw changes in the Railway Board as the post of chief commissioner was abolished and the chairman was appointed the most senior functional member. There was further reorganization in 1954 with an increase in the number of members to five to work alongside the chairman and the financial commissioner. More power was also given to the former, who was now responsible for technical and policy matters. Today, the Railway Board consists of eight members in addition to the chairman. The Board manages the administrative role under the purview of the Union Cabinet minister of the Indian Government. Each zone, in turn, is under the command of a general manager.

New places, new lines

Partition necessitated the building of two lines on an urgent basis and both started almost immediately in the years following Independence. The first, the [Assam relinking project](#), was a mammoth endeavour, which was completed in record time. The second, the Mukerian–Pathankot line in Punjab, proved to be of immense strategic importance amid growing hostilities with Pakistan. Within months of Independence, the countries fought a war over Kashmir; they would go on to fight again in 1965, 1971, and 1999.

Work on the 43-km-long line began in November 1949. It required extensive bridging and opened in April 1952. While it reduced the distance between Delhi and Pathankot by 70 km, Jammu in the north-west was still far away, so construction began to extend the line to